

SOUTHERN GLAZER'S / DIRECTOR OF PRODUCT OPERATIONS, AI/ML

Russell Dudek

Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania

Hiring Team,

Southern Glazer's does not need MLOps as a technical sidecar. The company is operating a large physical distribution network, a meaningful digital commerce platform, and - according to recent public reporting - a commercial model shifting toward field sales, inside sales, and digital commerce while leadership points to AI as part of adapting to the market. In that environment, the real product is confidence: confidence that a model is ready to release, observable in production, recoverable when conditions change, and connected to a business outcome.

That operating problem interests me. At Compunetics, I led across engineering, manufacturing, quality, delivery, and high-reliability technical programs, building quality systems, root-cause practices, measures, and controls. At Amazon, I built operating visibility, escalation paths, standard work, and leadership routines in a 24/7 customer-backward environment supporting approximately five million second-day orders annually. Today at Vape-Jet, I connect factory, customer, support, engineering, and machine-fleet signals into prioritized work, earlier risk detection, better handoffs, dashboards, training, and accountability in a software-enabled robotics and machine-vision environment with approximately 1,000 fielded robots.

Through DudeWorth, I also develop AI-readiness and workflow frameworks connecting value, feasibility, data readiness, evaluation, human judgment, escalation, decision records, governance, adoption burden, reuse, and time-to-value. My point of view is that governance only works when it is built into how work moves.

I should be direct about the strongest objection. My background is not a conventional seven-year progression through ML platform operations, and I will not rewrite it into one. The case for me is transferability: director-level leadership in technical and operating systems; deep experience with reliability, quality, controls, escalation, and adoption; current AI-first transformation work; and the ability to build the operating system around a technically strong platform team. If the role requires the director to be the deepest hands-on MLOps engineer in the room, I am not the obvious profile. If it requires a leader who can make reliability, ownership, governance, cross-functional decision rights, and business outcomes cohere around deep technical talent, that is a serious conversation.

My candidate thesis is a Model Reliability Contract: every production model should have explicit release evidence, live operating boundaries, named intervention rights, and a business-outcome owner. I have translated that thesis into a 120-day entry plan, decision architecture, hard-objection analysis, and a practical reliability-contract artifact.

I would value the chance to test that thinking against the realities of Southern Glazer's AIML platform organization.

Carpe diem,

Russell Dudek

Candidate vision: russelldudek.github.io/Glazer/